

H2GUARD · DESIGN PRECIS

H2Guard design precis

Design Molecule Lab · designmolecule.com

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Document ID	HGD-PRC-001	Version	0.7
Status	Draft	Date	2026-10-02
Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
Project TRL	TRL 3 Proof of concept		
Repository	github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/h2guard		
Source	docs/02-concept.md @ uncommitted		

REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.7	2026-10-02	Amish Chadha	Model, BOM and calculations updated to the decisions of 2026-10-02 (HGD-CAL-001 v0.4); components table, key numbers and safety notes brought into line; drawing HGD-DWG-001 to Rev P5
0.6	2026-10-02	Amish Chadha	Decisions of 2026-10-02 carried in: ceiling drop rod, pressure switch, hydrogen-rated valve, oxygen sensor option, set point sources, bump test, relay output, clear lid, fan motor rule
0.5	2026-10-01	Amish Chadha	Design made constructable (HGD-DDR-003) with a build plan (HGD-BLD-001); cost against the value-engineering target; drawing HGD-DWG-001 to Rev P4
0.4	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Recommendations accepted by Amish (DDR-002); timed escalation firmware rule, head placement rule, budget \$265, R13 scope; drawing HGD-DWG-001 to Rev P2
0.3	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	TRL 3 update; design choices adopted for TRL 3 per HGD-DDR-001 (pending

Amish's review); numbers from HGD-CAL-001; fan re-specified, thinner arrestors, bump test cup and port added; series trip relay; parametric model and drawing HGD-DWG-001

0.2	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Populate to TRL 2 (architecture, components, first-order numbers, design choices, safety, media)
0.1	2026-09-25	Amish Chadha	Initial scaffold

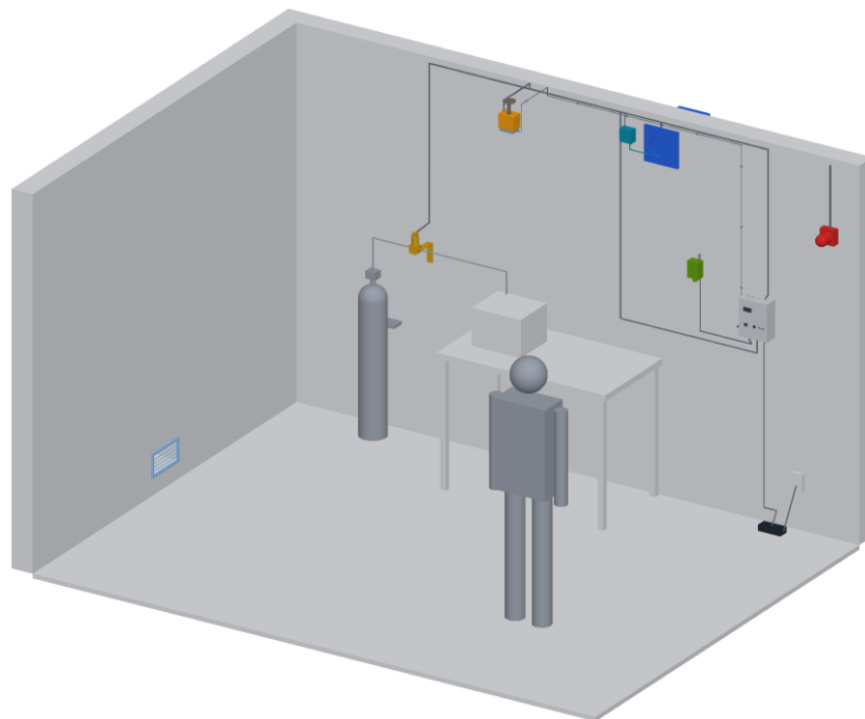
H2Guard design precis

H2Guard protects one small room where hydrogen is used. A detector head at the ceiling carries a catalytic sensor that reads 0 to 100 % of the lower flammability limit (LFL) and a metal oxide sensor for early warning. A wall controller at chest height keeps a 150 mm exhaust fan running at high level, holds a normally closed solenoid valve on the hydrogen supply open only while all is well, and drives a sounder and beacon. At 10 % LFL it warns and boosts the fan; at 25 % LFL it closes the valve and latches the alarm. Loss of power, a sensor fault, a stopped fan, lost airflow or a crashed controller all close the valve, and a hardware comparator opens a relay in series with the valve without the firmware. The TRL 3 calculations (HGD-CAL-001) give 35.7 s from a leak to the valve closing with an assumed 30 s sensor t_{90} , about 5 % LFL in the 30 m³ room for the 5 L/min design leak with the fan running, and an estimated cost of USD 411 for the constructable design against a USD 265 value-engineering target (USD 146 over). A warning held for 5 min also closes the supply, so a leak that the head sees off the plume axis is stopped within about 6 min. H2Guard is a research and teaching prototype, not a certified gas detection system.

H2Guard

github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/h2guard

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION



Grey figure: 1.75 m person for scale. Grey room, bench, gas store, supply line, cables and bump test tube are context.

Figure 1. H2Guard in the 30 m³ reference room, with a 1.75 m person for scale. Detector head (orange) on its ceiling drop rod over the bench apparatus, exhaust fan (blue) high on the back wall, make-up air grille low on the far side wall, solenoid valve (gold) on the supply line, controller with its bump test port, and beacon near the door. Grey parts are context. Built from the parametric model.

■ How it works

1. **Sense.** Hydrogen rises from a leak as a buoyant plume and spreads under the ceiling. The detector head hangs from the ceiling on a short drop rod directly above the likely leak point, with its sensor ports 175 mm below the ceiling. The placement rule (HGD-DDR-002) puts a head over each likely leak point, with a second head where leak points are far apart; the plume is only about 141 mm in radius at the ports, and the allowed horizontal offset is to be set from a measured plume width at TRL 4. The catalytic sensor measures 0 to 100 % LFL and sets the warning and trip. The metal oxide sensor responds from about 30 ppm and shows small, slow leaks as a trend long before the catalytic reading moves; it never trips the system alone, because humidity and other vapors affect it. Each sensor sits about 2 mm behind a 2 mm sintered arrestor disc, which adds about 1.5 s of lag.
2. **Decide.** The controller reads both sensors. The microcontroller handles set points, display, logging and self-test, and switches the valve through a MOSFET. In parallel, a hardware window comparator watches the catalytic sensor bridge: above the trip level, or if the bridge reads open or shorted, it sets a hardware latch that opens a relay in series with that MOSFET. Either switch opening closes the valve, and only the key resets the latch.
3. **Act.** - **Normal:** fan at continuous speed, valve energized (open), green light. - **Warning, 10 % LFL (0.4 % vol):** fan to boost, amber light, intermittent sounder. Clears itself when the reading falls. If the warning is held for 5 min, the microcontroller closes the valve and latches as for a trip (timed escalation, HGD-DDR-002). This is a firmware rule; the hardware comparator still acts only at 25 % LFL. - **Trip, 25 % LFL (1.0 % vol):** valve de-energized (closed), fan on boost, continuous sounder and red beacon. Latched: the supply stays closed until someone turns the reset key and the reading is below 10 % LFL. - **Fault:** any loss of 24 V power, sensor fault, heater failure, watchdog timeout (1 s), fan stop (no tachometer pulses for 10 s) or lost airflow (the pressure switch on the fan inlet not proving flow for 10 s with the fan running) closes the valve and shows the fault. A dry-contact relay, held while all is well, opens on a trip, a fault or loss of power so that H2Bench can cut its own supply.
4. **Ventilate.** The fan runs all the time, so it is never switched on in a flammable mixture, and so no gas can flow unless the room is being ventilated. Make-up air enters through a low grille on the far side of the room, sweeping the room toward the high exhaust.
5. **Record and test.** The controller logs readings, warnings, trips, faults and resets. A test button runs the sounder, beacon, fan boost and valve close. For a bump test, certified 1 % vol hydrogen span gas is connected to a capped port beside the controller; a 4 mm tube carries it up the cable route to a nozzle in the drip skirt under the head, which acts as a test cup. The reading settles in about 67 s. Because 1 % vol is the trip level, a full-span bump test also trips the system and proves the chain.

H2Guard: detect, decide, act chain for the design leak (HGD-CAL-001 estimates, 30 m3 room)
CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

github.com/BoujeeEnjin1701/h2guard



Figure 2. Detect, decide and act chain for the design leak in the 30 m3 reference room, with values from HGD-CAL-001. They are estimates; the sensor t_{90} is an assumption not yet confirmed from a datasheet.

■ Main components

Table 1. Main components. Numbers match `bom/bom.csv`, Figure 3 and drawing HGD-DWG-001.

#	Component	Choice	Notes
1	Detector head enclosure	ABS or polycarbonate box 110 x 80 x 90 mm, two 22 mm sensor ports facing down	On the ceiling drop rod (17) directly above the source, ports 175 mm below the ceiling
2	Catalytic hydrogen sensor	Catalytic (pellistor) sensor with hydrogen response, 0 to 100 % LFL, for example Figaro TGS6812	Primary trip sensor; needs oxygen and can be poisoned by silicones
3	Metal oxide hydrogen sensor	About 30 to 3,000 ppm, for example Figaro TGS2616-C00	Early warning and trend only
4	Flame arrestor discs and bump test cup	Sintered stainless discs 25 x 2 mm, pores 50 µm or less; drip skirt 96 x 66 x 22 mm forming the test cup	Not a certified flameproof assembly
5	Controller enclosure	IP65 polycarbonate wall box 200 x 250 x 90 mm with a clear lid, eight cable glands	Top 1,025 mm below the ceiling
6	Controller board	RP2040-class microcontroller with 4 MB flash; comparator with hardware latch and series relay; drivers for valve, fan and alarm; tachometer and pressure switch inputs; event log	Firmware beyond a labeled sketch is TRL 4 work
7	Front panel	OLED display, key-switch reset, test button, status lights	The key keeps students from clearing a trip
8	24 V DC power supply	Certified plug-in supply, 24 V, 60 W	Only mains part; bought certified
9	Exhaust fan	150 mm mixed-flow EC duct fan, 24 V, about 450 m ³ /h free air, 200 Pa shut-off, tachometer; grille, sleeve, backdraft shutter, weather hood	Re-specified at TRL 3; runs continuously at about 43 % speed
10	Make-up air grille	Low-level wall grille 300 x 160 mm with insect mesh	Far side of the room from the fan
11	Normally closed solenoid valve	1/4 in, direct acting, stainless steel, rated for hydrogen with a stated seat leak rate, 24 V DC, 0 to 10 bar, Zener clamp	After the regulator; closes on loss of power
12	Sounder and beacon	24 V, about 90 dB at 1 m, red flashing	By the door, top 450 mm below the ceiling
15	Bump test port and tube	Capped push-fit port beside the controller, about 3.1 m of 4 mm tube across the ceiling to the cup nozzle	New at TRL 3 for R12
17	Ceiling drop rod	1/2 in floor flange on the ceiling, 89 mm pipe nipple, locknuts either side of the head top	Holds the head with its ports over the apparatus
18	Differential pressure switch	Low-range air pressure switch beside the fan, tubed to a static tap in the fan inlet	Proves airflow; no flow closes the valve
19	Dry-contact output	Relay and 2-way terminal on the controller mounting plate	Opens on a trip, a fault or loss of power
20	Oxygen sensor (option)	Electrochemical transmitter, 4 to 20 mA, cell at breathing height	Fitted whenever inert gas cylinders share the room
21		Bifurcated 150 mm duct fan in place of line 9	

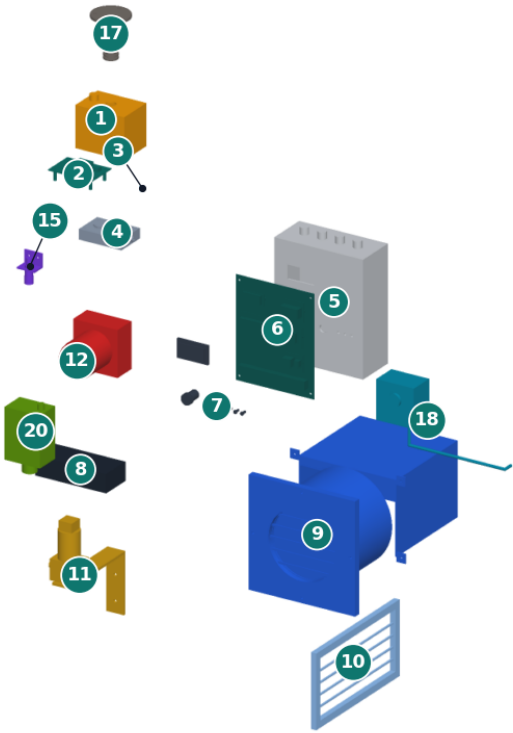
#	Component	Choice	Notes
	Fan with motor outside the air stream (option)		For rooms used without close supervision

H2Guard: exploded view

github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/h2guard

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Detector head enclosure
- 2 Catalytic H2 sensor, 0 to 100 % LFL
- 3 MOS H2 sensor, early warning
- 4 Flame arrestors and bump test cup
- 5 Controller enclosure
- 6 Controller board, series trip relay
- 7 Front panel: display, key reset, test
- 8 24 V DC supply, certified
- 9 Exhaust fan, 150 mm mixed flow
- 10 Make-up air grille, low level
- 11 NC solenoid valve, hydrogen rated
- 12 Sounder and beacon
- 15 Bump test port (tube shown grey)
- 17 Ceiling drop rod for the head
- 18 Pressure switch proving airflow
- 20 Oxygen sensor (option)



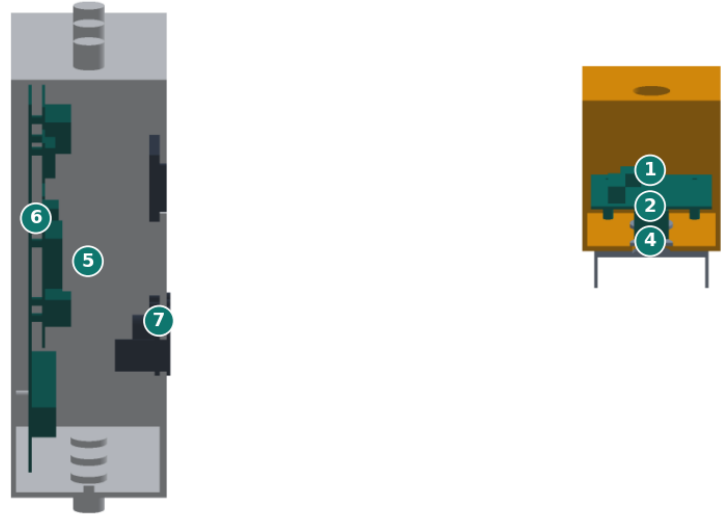
Seen from the front right and above, 24 deg elevation; numbers match bom/bom.csv

Figure 3. Exploded view of the H2Guard parts with BOM numbers. Cabling (BOM line 13), fixings (line 14), the dry-contact relay (line 19, on the controller board) and the alternative fan (line 21) are not shown separately.

H2Guard: section through detector head (right) and controller (left)github.com/BoujeeEnjinia1701/h2guard

CONCEPT, NOT FOR FABRICATION

- 1 Detector head enclosure
- 2 Catalytic H₂ sensor, 0 to 100 % LFL
- 4 Flame arrestors and bump test cup
- 5 Controller enclosure
- 6 Controller board, series trip relay
- 7 Front panel: display, key reset, test



Head shown beside the controller; installed on its ceiling drop rod with its ports 175 mm below the ceiling. MOS sensor (3) is behind the cut plane.

Figure 4. Sections through the controller (left) and the detector head (right), each cut on a vertical plane and seen from the side. The head section passes through the catalytic sensor, its arrestor disc and the bump test cup. The head is drawn beside the controller for this view.

The general arrangement drawing [HGD-DWG-001](#) (Rev P5) gives the mounting heights and main dimensions from the parametric model `cad/src/model.py`. The blueprint concept sheet (PDF) and the [interactive 3D model](#) show the parts in place. The design is constructable: every part can be made or bought and has a fixing (HGD-DDR-003), and the [prototype build plan](#) (HGD-BLD-001) shows how each is made and fitted. The changes for construction are the openings in the bump test cup, 22 mm ports with the arrestor discs bonded on a ledge, standoffs that hold the sensor board and cup, a mounting plate and drilled lid in the controller, a bracket for the test port, a 200 mm wall sleeve and fan plate for the fan, and a bracket for the valve. The decisions of 2026-10-02 added the ceiling drop rod, the pressure switch, the dry-contact output and the oxygen sensor option to the model.

■ Key numbers

All values are from HGD-CAL-001, which gives the method and assumptions. They are first-principles estimates.

Table 2. Key numbers for the 30 m³ reference room and the 5 L/min design leak.

Quantity	Value
Hydrogen from a 100 W electrolyzer	0.39 L/min
Ceiling layer (0.3 m) to 25 % LFL without ventilation	7.2 min (whole room mixed: 60 min)
Room and upper layer with 150 m ³ /h exhaust	5.0 % LFL (2.5 % LFL on boost)
Plume at the detector head	About 15 % LFL mean, about 30 % LFL on the plume axis
Leak to valve closed	35.7 s with an assumed 30 s sensor t ₉₀ ; 0.17 s from trip to closed
Hydrogen released before closing	3.0 L, plus 0.47 L in the line downstream
Fan delivery against duct losses	347 m ³ /h at full speed (the TRL 2 fan gave 237 m ³ /h)
Inventory limit	300 L at 1 atm (25.1 g); a 0.13 mm orifice at 10 bar gauge limits a failure to 5 L/min
Power	13.5 W normal, 48.7 W warning, 40.3 W trip (49.2 W peak with the oxygen sensor)
Airflow proving	Fan inlet tap 5.7 Pa at 150 m ³ /h, 30.5 Pa at full speed; switch set at about 2.8 Pa; no flow gives about 0 Pa
Bump test	About 67 s; 1.36 L of span gas per test
Timed escalation, off-axis design leak	Valve closed at 5.6 min, 28 L released, room about 1.9 % LFL
Estimated cost	Value-engineering target: USD 265. Estimated cost of the constructable design: USD 411 (USD 146 over the target); oxygen sensor option USD 110 more

Two findings matter for the design. First, the design leak trips the system only if the head is on the plume axis; beside it, the head sees about 15 % LFL and warns without closing the supply, although the room stays at about 5 % LFL. Second, a fan rated at the boost flow in free air cannot deliver it through a real duct, so the fan is re-specified. Amish accepted two remedies for the first on 2026-09-25 (HGD-DDR-002): the timed escalation and the head placement rule. On 2026-10-02 he decided that the head hangs on a ceiling drop rod directly over the apparatus; the model now puts the ports 0 mm from the apparatus centre, inside the plume.

■ Key design choices

The choices below are decided by Amish, 2026-09-25: go with recommendation (HGD-DDR-001, confirmed by HGD-DDR-002).

- 1. Catalytic sensor for the trip, metal oxide sensor for early warning (D1).** Options were (a) catalytic plus metal oxide (about \$50 of sensors); (b) a certified molecular property spectrometer sensor (about \$249, t₉₀ under 20 s, poisoning resistant, [NevadaNano](#)); (c) metal oxide only. Adopted: (a) for the teaching prototype, with (b) documented as the upgrade for any room used without close supervision.
- 2. Normally closed valve, energize to open (D3).** Fail-safe on power loss, at the cost of 8 W of coil power all the time.

3. **Independent hardware trip** (D8). A comparator with its own latch opens a relay in series with the microcontroller's valve switch, so a firmware bug cannot hold the valve open.
4. **Continuous ventilation with a boost** (D4). Avoids switching a motor on in a flammable mixture and proves fan rotation before gas can flow.
5. **Set points 10 % LFL (warn) and 25 % LFL (trip)** (D2). More conservative than the 25 % and 50 % levels often used in industry.
6. **24 V DC throughout, with a certified plug-in supply** (D9).
7. **Key-switch reset** (D6). Stops students from clearing a trip without a supervisor.
8. **One detector head per room** (D6). A second head is an option where the ceiling has beams or pockets, or where leak points are far apart (see Key numbers).
9. **Timed escalation** (HGD-DDR-002). A warning held for 5 min closes the valve and latches. Options were (a) this; (b) a lower trip at 20 % LFL; (c) warning only for small leaks. Decided: (a).
10. **Head placement rule** (HGD-DDR-002). A head directly above each likely leak point, with the horizontal offset limit set from the plume width at TRL 4. On 2026-10-02 Amish decided that the head hangs from the ceiling on a drop rod directly over the apparatus; wall mounting is allowed only if the TRL 4 plume test shows a trip at the wall position.

Decided by Amish on 2026-10-02 (HGD-DEC-001):

- **Airflow proven by a differential pressure switch** at the fan, as well as the tachometer. The switch reads the depression in the fan inlet against the room, which falls to about zero whether the fan stops, the duct is blocked or the shutter sticks.
- **A valve rated for hydrogen with a stated seat leak rate.** The low-cost brass valve is accepted only if its maker states hydrogen compatibility and a seat leak rating and it passes a seat leak proof test at TRL 4.
- **Oxygen sensor** as a standard kit option whenever inert gas cylinders share the room.
- **Set points** from the stricter of the national code and ISO 26142, and from the host institution's safety office where its rules are stricter; 10 % and 25 % LFL stay the defaults.
- **Full-span bump test** with 1 % hydrogen that trips the system; the pass level is set once the cup delivery factor is measured.
- **Dry-contact relay output** that opens on a trip or loss of power, for H2Bench to cut its own supply.
- **Clear-lid IP65 controller box**, so the lights and display show without opening it.
- **Fan motor in the sleeve** for the supervised teaching prototype only; a fan with its motor outside the air stream for any room used without close supervision.

■ Relation to other lab projects

- **H2Bench** is the first host. Its README states that it is "Protected by H2Guard", and its gas system (electrolyzer, low-pressure store, regulator and tubing) is where the valve and any flow restrictor go. The inventory rule (R9, D5) applies to H2Bench's storage; its 2 L tank at 300 kPa gauge holds 7.9 L, 2.6 % of the limit. H2Bench's review asks for interlock outputs to cut its power supply and close its tank solenoid; H2Guard now has a dry-contact relay output that opens on a trip or loss of power, for H2Bench to cut its own supply (decided 2026-10-02); H2Bench still has to wire it into its supply.
- H2Guard does not use a SwapCell pack or any lithium cell, and it does not depend on FieldNode, CellGuard, MotionCore, ThermaCart, TwinKit or CalRig.

■ Safety

Safety: Hydrogen is flammable in air from about 4 % to 74 % by volume and ignites with very little energy. H2Guard is a research and teaching prototype, not a certified gas detection system, and it must not be the only safeguard in any room where codes or insurers require certified detection. Use certified equipment for any real installation.

Safety: The parts are not certified for hazardous areas. The catalytic sensor element runs hot, and the fan motor, relays and supply are possible ignition sources. The motor in the exhaust sleeve is accepted only for the supervised teaching prototype; a room used without close supervision needs a fan with its motor outside the air stream. The design limits this by keeping the controller and supply low on the wall, running the fan continuously and fitting flame arrestors to the sensor ports, but it does not remove the risk.

Safety: The design leak assumes a flow restrictor. A failed regulator on an unrestricted high-pressure cylinder can release gas far faster than the fan can remove it. Keep inventories within the R9 limit (300 L at atmospheric pressure for the 30 m³ room) or fit a restrictor, and have gas fittings made and leak-tested by a competent person.

Safety: Catalytic sensors need oxygen and can be poisoned by silicones, sulfur compounds and some solvents, which makes them read low without warning. Bump test before each teaching session and after any exposure to these vapors, and replace the sensor when it fails a bump test. An oxygen-poor room makes the catalytic sensor read low, so fit the oxygen sensor option whenever inert gas cylinders share the room.

Safety: The pressure switch now detects a blocked duct or a stuck shutter, but a leaking valve seat is still not detected in operation (HGD-CAL-001, Table 4). It is covered by the valve's stated hydrogen and seat leak ratings and by a seat leak proof test at TRL 4; until that test is done, check that the valve closes at every session, and prove the pressure switch at commissioning by covering its inlet tap.

Safety: Mains power enters only through a certified plug-in supply. Do not open it or wire mains inside the controller.

■ Open questions

- Confirm t₉₀, power and poisoning behavior of the chosen catalytic sensor from its datasheet, and whether its hydrogen output gives 1 % LFL resolution (R1, R4).
- Measure the delivery factor of the open bump test cup and set the bump test pass level (the 1 % full-span test trips the system, decided 2026-10-02).
- Airflow proving, the valve, set point sources and oxygen monitoring were decided on 2026-10-02 (listed under the key design choices; HGD-DDR-001, O2 to O5).
- The horizontal offset limit for the head placement rule, from a measured plume width (TRL 4, on hold).